COUNTRY REPORTS: NIGER

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Status report

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Niger has been running its digital programme without an adopted national digital policy. The national digital-development policy had been drafted but not adopted as of March 2025, and a year later a National Digital Development Policy for 2026-2035 and a sectoral digital development plan for 2026-2030, carrying an axis on digital governance and e-government, were still in validation as of March 2026. The elaboration of a national cybersecurity strategy was still listed among the government's structural reforms in July 2025.

Sectoral policy has gone further than the framework above it. Niger has adopted a national e-Agriculture strategy whose costed 2023-2027 action plan carries 22 projects and 37 actions, developed with GIZ and FAO support and aiming explicitly at future interoperability between agricultural data platforms. Delivery-side committees have also been stood up ahead of the strategies, among them a national committee installed on 23 July 2025 to deploy and operationalise the country's critical digital infrastructures.

Policy passes through the transition's own institutions. Niger is governed by General Abdourahamane Tiani as President of the Republic, and the consultative body of the Refondation is where systems are now explained before they are built out: the public-service minister presented SIGRHEP, the human-resources system for state agents, to the Conseil Consultatif de la Refondation on 27 July 2026.

The wider record is of slow erosion. Overall governance scored 47.9 out of 100 in 2023, 30th of 54 African states and below the continental average of 49.3, down 2.5 points over the decade as the rank slipped from 23rd to 30th; Niger sits below the African average on 50 of the index's 96 indicators, and declined on 49 of them between 2014 and 2023 against 43 improvements.

Legislation and regulation

Niger rebuilt the legal basis of identity in the spring of 2026. Ordonnance n°2026-21 of 22 April 2026 sets the civil-status regime, décrets n°2026-242 and n°2026-243 of the same day create ANEI, the national civil-status and identification agency, and set its statutes, and décret n°2026-277 of 18 May 2026 is the application text for the ordonnance. From 14 August 2026 a national awareness tour opened at Dosso to put those instruments to the population the registers are meant to enrol.

One ordonnance and three décrets, the whole identity stack, were enacted inside the 27 days from 22 April to 18 May 2026.

Data law is settled but narrow. Loi n°2022-59 of 16 December 2022 replaced the 2017 statute and was amended by loi n°2023-31 of 4 July 2023, governing the collection, processing and transfer of personal data including biometric data. No data localisation requirement applies: personal, government, financial and critical-infrastructure data may

be held abroad. And no dedicated law establishes cross-government data-sharing authority or governs a national data exchange, the nearest instruments being the 2018 Telecommunications Code, the 2019 law on electronic transactions and the December 2022 data protection law.

Telecommunications is the most actively enforced field. The regulator is constituted by loi n°2018-47 of 12 July 2018, which also requires its director general to swear an oath before taking office; Moussa Zeinabou Seyni swore it before the Cour d'appel de Niamey on 25 February 2026, having been appointed by décret n°2026-071/PRN/PM of 30 January 2026, so the court receives the oath without any say in the choice. In September 2025 ARCEP served formal notice on commercial "Wifi Zones" reselling Starlink connectivity, invoking articles 16 and 23 of loi 2018-45 and setting a 3 October deadline to cease or regularise, against penalties of three months to a year in prison and fines up to 60 million FCFA, plus 6 to 12 million per non-homologated terminal. SIM identification is the older rule, mandatory since décret n°2012-433 of 4 October 2012 and enforced in November 2013 by the deactivation of some 1.7 million unidentified cards, roughly a third of subscribers.

Data protection

Niger's data protection supervisor no longer exists. The government abolished the Haute Autorité de Protection des Données à Caractère Personnel by decree in June 2026 and transferred its prerogatives to the ministries of justice and of the interior, as part of a wider administrative reorganisation. The law itself stands: loi n°2022-59 of 16 December 2022 repealed and replaced the 2017 statute and has since been amended by loi n°2023-31 of 4 July 2023 and by ordonnances n°2024-16 and n°2024-29, governing the collection, processing and transfer of personal data including biometric data. Loi n°2019-71 of 24 December 2019, amending the 2017 law, governed the field before it and underpinned the authority's mandate.

Until its abolition the authority had operated since its installation in 2020 as Niger's independent data-protection authority, conducting inspections, referring offences to the courts and imposing administrative and financial sanctions, its decisions appealable to the Conseil d'Etat. The consolidated law also defines artificial intelligence at article 57 and requires developers, manufacturers and service providers operating from Niger to declare to that authority, and restricts fully automated decisions and profiling at article 52. The law gives individuals a right of access — confirmation that their data are processed, a copy of what is held, and its origin, purpose and recipients — which the authority publishes on its own site and which reaches data held in identity systems. Breach notification is mandatory: a controller must notify the authority without delay and, where the breach presents a high risk, tell the data subjects too. Data may leave the country only to states offering equivalent protection and with the authority's authorisation, no localisation requirement standing in the way; a 2020 decree set the authorisation procedure and the authority issued an application form for transfers to third countries under articles 30 to 34 of the 2022 law. No procedure has been published since the authority's abolition.

The regional obligation runs wider. ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 requires every state in its perimeter to legislate for personal data protection and to establish its own independent authority, with immunity, freedom from instruction and incompatibility with government office or telecom and information-sector shareholdings, authorisation of transborder transfers among that authority's powers, and transfer outside the community only where the destination affords adequate protection and the authority has been notified in advance. Its article 48 conditions entry into force on publication in both the Community's Official Journal and each member state's Official Gazette, so a state that never gazettes it occupies a position the instrument provides for.

Protection of the freedoms that surround the data has moved the other way. Digital Freedom — online censorship, government internet shutdowns and the freedom to organise online — fell 10.0 points over 2014-2023 to 38.5 out of 100, 40th of 54 African states.

Regional collaboration

Niger withdrew from ECOWAS in 2024 with Mali and Burkina Faso, leaving the bloc's shared regional digital rails and building the same interoperability through the Alliance of Sahel States instead. Its position was already weakening before the exit: Regional Integration — trade, movement and regulatory alignment with neighbours — scored 41.3 out of 100 in 2023, 32nd of 54 African states and down 2.9 points over the decade.

Monetary integration is untouched by the departure, and it is where most of Niger's working regional plumbing sits. The BCEAO itself operates the SICA-UEMOA retail clearing system and the STAR-UEMOA real-time gross settlement system that the country's banks and Treasury use, and there is no Niger-only instant retail payment system. Supplying payment services is governed union-wide by BCEAO Instruction n°001-01-2024 and customer identification by Instruction n°003-03-2025 of 18 March 2025. Beyond the union, Niger reaches the PAPSS network for inbound payments only, through a licensed extended-network partner's mobile wallet rather than as a direct participant (June 2026).

The identity credential has followed the political realignment. Niger's national card is the harmonised AES biometric credential, taken up as the alliance's second member after Burkina Faso and allowing passport-free travel between the three states. The World Bank identification programme did not stop with the withdrawal: WURI opened a pilot in May 2025 to issue birth certificates to 21,202 children under five at Filingué, and the 2026 civil-status and identification revisions are supported by it in restructured form.

Technical cooperation continues outside the treaty question. Niger hosted the 13th AfricaCERT Handshake symposium in Niamey in July 2025, opened by Prime Minister and Finance Minister Zeine. In September 2026 the confederation's regulators organised themselves: its media and communication regulators created a platform at Niamey on 18 September, with its seat and executive secretariat in the city, and its telecoms regulators signed a cooperation convention naming border frequency coordination, mutual recognition of type-approved equipment, free roaming and coordinated 5G as working files, its statutes still to be adopted.

Standards

ARCEP inaugurated a permanent platform for continuous monitoring of mobile networks in January 2026, built on the TRAFSCAN, QUALCOP and NETFIX systems supplied by the Tunisian vendor INFOCOM, giving the regulator its own measurement of service quality rather than the operators' returns.

The national standards, metrology and certification agency ANMC is an ISO correspondent member, created by decrees of 2019 within the UEMOA and ECOWAS quality framework, and its catalogue of national standards, as published in 2020, runs from agri-food to electrotechnical with no information-technology or data catalogue.

Outside network quality, the technical rules that bind Niger are written regionally. BCEAO Instruction n°001-01-2024 is the standing text for supplying payment services, binding banks, credit finance houses, payment institutions, microfinance institutions and electronic-money issuers alike and abrogating contrary earlier provisions; surveillance of financial-market infrastructures and of payment means and services runs under Instruction n°001-03-2021; and the operating rules of the systems themselves — settlement finality, priority processing, settlement-account checks, participation requirements — are published.

Electronic signature has no regional standard to inherit. As at April 2024 West Africa had no certified electronic-signature policy: an ECOWAS and EU Digital for Development Hub expert meeting held online on 26-27 March 2024 worked from the Malabo Convention and the ECOWAS Supplementary Act on electronic transactions, formulated guidelines, and left the roadmap still being defined.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Criticism of the state online is prosecuted. Prosecutors sought five years on 6 October 2026 against a lawyer charged under the cybercrime law with spreading data likely to disturb public order, over a Facebook post on divisions in the army, and a journalist missing since 31 August was acknowledged detained only on 25 September. The media regulator suspended nine French outlets on 8 May 2026 for content it said threatened public order, with four journalists jailed since 2025.

Niger is explaining its identity reforms to the country's authorities rather than debating them with its citizens. A national sensitisation tour is working region by region through administrative and traditional authorities — reaching Agadez on 28 August 2026 as its fourth stage — covering the National Population Register, the biometric national identity card, the WURI project and the operationalisation of the national identification agency.

The room for a wider argument has narrowed over the decade. Media Freedom fell 12.3 points to 59.4 out of 100 in 2023, 18th of 54 African states, and Freedom of Expression & Belief fell 10.8 points to 64.2, 24th of 54. What the state publishes is not the constraint: Niger discloses public records considerably more readily than citizens can actually reach them, and Nigeriens rate their own infrastructure far above its measured position. The council of ministers approved an overhaul of the media framework on 10 September 2026, tightening accreditation for foreign correspondents and carrying a draft ordinance that would require online press publishers to be identified and make digital newsrooms legally responsible for what they carry; the text is not published.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Donor money for Niger's digital estate falls away in the 2026 finance law, leaving the state's own lines at more than half: the 2025 law had carried a 14.7 billion CFA franc grant-financed line to connect 2,175 localities and 6.2 billion for mass identity registration, while the largest externally financed digital line in the 2026 law is 3.0 billion to connect schools and health posts under the Smart Villages project (2026).

The domestically financed share of the digital lines is 54.5% of 20.9 billion CFA francs appropriated in 2026, up from 19.5% of 69.3 billion in 2025; the external side fell to 9.5 billion from 55.9 billion, and the domestic side eased to 11.4 billion from 13.5 billion (2026).

The tax administration pays for its own digitisation from a levy. The 2025 finance law created a special account for the digital modernisation of the tax administration, credited with a 0.25% levy on the turnover of firms managed by the large-enterprise directorate plus a state subsidy, with a ceiling of 8.22 billion CFA francs (2025); the 2026 law caps it at 5.56 billion (2026). The provisional year-end execution report for 2025 reports spending by economic title only, and no outturn against the digital appropriations had been published as at September 2026.

The external windows are closing. The Smart Villages loan runs to 2026 and the regional identity programme's second phase to 2027; the 2026 law's own-budget identity line is 350 million CFA francs for the civil-status directorates' running costs and payments to registry centres (2026). The Trans-Saharan backbone and data-centre project carries more than 30 billion CFA francs from the African Development Bank, 16.0 billion as credit and 12.76 billion as grant, against a national counterpart of 2.17 billion (March 2026).

Identity is being financed by a vendor and by fees. The passport system is a public-private partnership under which the Libyan firm Al Itissal Al Jadeed finances, builds and maintains it (June 2025), and an ordinary passport costs 45,000 CFA francs (September 2026). The revenue terms of that partnership had not been published as at September 2026.

MoUs and other agreements

Niger's digital cooperation agreements are recent and bilateral. The Algerian state operator signed two conventions in Niamey on 8 September 2026, covering a skills centre at the telecoms school, training for Niger Telecom's staff and donated equipment for a fibre link on the national backbone, and Niger and Chad signed a protocol in June 2025 to implement their cross-border fibre interconnection. No text of either instrument is on the record.

New investments

Niger's largest live external digital commitment is the World Bank's USD 100 million Smart Villages for Rural Growth and Digital Inclusion loan, approved in 2020 and running to 2026, a commitment at approval rather than money disbursed. The largest commitment of any kind was never a live one: China Eximbank's RMB 623.7 million concessional loan for the national fibre backbone closed in 2017, and repayment runs from 31 December 2020 to 28 December 2033, so Niger will be servicing a network committed in 2014 for close to two decades — longer than the equipment's expected life.

As at September 2026 five distinct external digital commitments are on the record, with start years from 2014 to 2021 and end dates reaching 2027, together worth roughly USD 222 million. The mix is overwhelmingly debt: three concessional loans account for about USD 212 million of that, alongside a single Netherlands grant of EUR 6.8 million and a USD 2 million political risk guarantee, and no equity investment recorded. The World Bank is the largest financier, at about USD 108 million across two Niger-specific operations, closely followed by China Eximbank at about USD 104 million in one loan. Backbone connectivity (about USD 104 million) and rural digital inclusion (about USD 100 million) take almost all of it, leaving roughly USD 10 million for digital payments and fintech and about USD 8 million for agricultural information systems. Only two of the five are still running, both World Bank loans and worth about USD 108 million between them; the Chinese backbone loan, the Netherlands agritech grant and the payments guarantee have all closed.

Beyond that record, the Trans-Saharan fibre backbone and Tier III data centre project is financed at around 30 billion FCFA by the African Development Bank, the African Development Fund and the national counterpart (November 2025). Foundational digital identity is paid for from outside the state budget, under the World Bank's four-country WURI Phase 2 operation running to 2027, and the digital payment work for urban cash transfers — a feasibility study, a payment model and the system itself — sits as a component inside the Adaptive Safety Net Project 2.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Niger took provisional acceptance in November 2025 of 1,031 km of optical fibre laid on five cross-border axes towards Algeria, Chad, Nigeria, Benin and Burkina Faso under the Trans-Saharan backbone project. Three months earlier the country had inaugurated a domestic internet exchange point, giving traffic between Nigerien networks somewhere to meet without first leaving the country. The regulator opened a consultation on 20 July 2026 proposing the 600 MHz, 700 MHz and 3.5 GHz bands for 5G, after adopting a 2025 national frequency allocation plan in June.

Beneath that sits a Chinese-financed layer. China Eximbank committed RMB 623.7 million — about US$103.8 million in constant 2023 dollars — in January 2014 for the national backbone, more than 2,275 km of fibre on the Niamey–Tillabéry, Zinder–Diffa and Agadez–Tahoua routes, handed over to the authorities in the first quarter of 2017. The loan carries a twenty-year maturity, a seven-year grace period and 1% interest, with servicing scheduled to run into the 2030s.

Satellite arrived next. Commercial Starlink sales opened on 13 March 2025, on the strength of a partnership the Nigerien state signed with SpaceX in October 2024, making Niger the seventeenth African market the service entered. A Nigerien-owned distributor launched a kit distribution campaign at the end of April 2025. In January 2026 Airtel Niger commercialised "Starlink by Airtel", under which the operator rather than the customer holds the Starlink relationship. Onward resale is not permitted, and in September 2025 the regulator gave commercial Wifi Zones running on Starlink until 3 October to stop or regularise. The regime is now written down: an order signed on 30 June 2026 licenses community Wi-Fi zones against a file fee of 50,000 CFA francs and annual royalties of 50,000 to 200,000 a zone, bans signal amplifiers and gives existing operators three months to comply, and the providers' collective contests its equipment rules and fees.

The measured position remains among Africa's weakest. Infrastructure is Niger's worst-scoring of the 2024 Ibrahim Index's sixteen sub-categories at 28.1 out of 100, 42nd of 54 African states, and also the country's second most improved, up 8.7 points over 2014-2023. Mobile communications rose 19.1 points to 47.0 but still rank 47th, and internet and computers rose 16.8 points to 30.6, at 30th (2023). Mobile connections were equivalent to 59.4% of the population in January 2024, while fewer than a fifth of Nigeriens used the internet in 2024. Citizens rate the result far better than the measurement does: public perception of infrastructure stands at 59.6, tenth of 54 in Africa (2023). The Nigerien and Algerian ministers launched operation of the fibre link between In Guezzam and Arlit-Agadez at the border on 6 October 2026; Algeria's account gives a starting capacity of 100 Gbps.

Data Storage

A Tier III data centre is being built at Niamey as the second component of the Trans-Saharan backbone project, its commissioning still ahead when the fibre sections were received in November 2025, presented by the government as securing the sovereignty of state data. It had been announced in March 2025 as a national data centre to hold and secure all of the state's data, built with African Development Bank support at 9.5 billion CFA francs, 13 per cent executed, and promised for delivery by 30 September that year, a project put at about US$14.3 million.

Nothing obliges data to stay in the country. Niger imposes no data localisation requirement, so personal, government, financial and critical-infrastructure data may be held abroad, subject only to the data protection law's conditions that cross-border transfers go to countries offering equivalent protection and be authorised by the HAPDP.

Shared hosting beyond the state's own estate is already in use in finance, where a mutualised processing centre sited in Côte d'Ivoire and Niger did the work that brought twelve microfinance institutions into the UEMOA clearing system through partner banks (2023).

Energy

Electrification is sharply urban: 67.4% of the urban population had electricity access in 2023 against 10.4% of the rural population, a gap of 57 percentage points. Nationally electricity reaches 20.1% of the population (2023), and access to energy is among Niger's ten worst Ibrahim Index indicators at 10.4 out of 100, 49th of 54 African states, having gained only 3.4 points over the decade to 2023.

The rules are far ahead of the wires. World Bank RISE scoring credits Niger with a current officially approved electrification plan at 82 out of 100 for governance, and a dedicated mini-grids framework scoring 65 that covers solar hybrid programmes and diesel-to-solar hybridisation (2024). What that has produced on the ground is modest: the Niger Solar Electricity Access Project, closed in December 2024, delivered new solar mini-grid connections to around 1,464 households and hybridised existing NIGELEC mini-grids serving around 19,283 households.

For anything that has to stay switched on, supply itself is the constraint. 78% of firms were affected by electrical outages, at an average of around 22 outages a month (2017). Under a tenth of electricity generation comes from renewable sources, the country relying instead on thermal generation and cross-border imports (2021), and the regulated residential tariff has been held unchanged despite rising supply costs (2024).

Technical Capacity

Niger has assigned the Agence Nationale pour la Société de l'Information a systems-integration role in the identity stack, alongside support for the biometric identity card production service and the territorial surveillance directorate (August 2026). The building of those systems is contracted outside the state: the interior ministry signed two memoranda in June 2025 with a Libyan firm covering the financing, construction and maintenance of the biometric e-ID and e-passport systems.

Operator numbers inside government are small. The SIGRHEP personnel system being put in place reaches at least 150 human-resources and payroll managers across the public service (July 2026), and donor-funded IT equipment and computer training for the police, including biometric kit, has gone to specialised judicial-police and territorial-surveillance units (2023).

Domestic training carries some volume: the Université Islamique du Niger's Faculté des Sciences et Techniques has produced over 1,200 ICT and telecommunications graduates since 2009 (2022). ANSI names human competence alongside infrastructure among its stated pillars (July 2025).

Cybersecurity

The Council of Ministers created the Centre National de Cybersécurité by decree on 11 October 2025 and approved its statutes, naming it the institution coordinating implementation of Niger's 2022 national cybersecurity strategy, and adopted alongside it the decree organising the Agence Nigérienne de Certification Électronique under articles 17 and 18 of loi n°2019-03. The prime minister listed the elaboration of a national cybersecurity strategy among the government's structural reforms in July 2025. Niger scored 41.86 out of 100 in the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, in the index's "establishing" tier.

The government installed a national committee on 23 July 2025 to deploy and operationalise the country's critical digital infrastructures, presented as essential to national digital sovereignty and security. Its remit enumerates six components: a national public key infrastructure, a National Cybersecurity Centre housing a security operations centre and a CERT, a national internet exchange point, government Tier III+ reference data centres, a national digital forensics laboratory, and the national fibre backbone with metropolitan loops. The cybersecurity centre sits on that list among the things still to be deployed.

One of those six, the national fibre backbone, had reached provisional acceptance by November 2025; a second, a Tier III government data centre, was still being built.

Where systems are being built, sovereignty is the stated design principle: ANSI's director general set data sovereignty and encryption of every transaction and information item as the basis of Niamey's municipal tax platform (January 2025). The agency has said it wants to turn its AfricaCERT contacts into a cyber-defence alliance among Alliance of Sahel States members, having hosted the thirteenth AfricaCERT Handshake symposium in Niamey in July 2025. Duties on holders of data already exist: a controller must notify the HAPDP of a personal data breach without delay and, where the breach presents a high risk, inform the people affected.

DPI

Data Exchange

The interoperability framework meant to connect Niger's digital identity to public and private service providers — employment, justice, migration and passports, payments, national statistics and social protection are all named beneficiaries — is financed under component 3 of the WURI-Niger project and has not been built. A support mission in February 2026 settled the target technical architecture for linking civil registration to the national identification system and created an inter-institutional task force coordinated by the digital agency ANSI, and a Council of Ministers communiqué of 22 April 2026 records that the gaps in interoperability between civil registration and identification remain open, with the enabling legal reforms still in draft.

Niger has not developed an e-government interoperability framework, and its business, electoral, civil registration and land registers each remain siloed with no connection to any cross-government data exchange platform (2024). The tax register is not integrated with any national identity system: individual taxpayer registration turns on a civil status document rather than an identity card number. The nearest instruments are loi n°2019-03 of 30 April 2019, which frames electronic transactions, electronic signature, data retention and the penalties for breaching them, the telecommunications code and the personal data protection law of December 2022. The Council of Ministers of 18 May 2026 adopted the decree defining management of the Registre National de l'Etat Civil and expressly providing interoperability mechanisms between it, the Registre National de la Population and other functional systems, with a national unique identifier for every Nigerien and for long and short-term foreign residents — the first named mechanism, and it covers identity rather than government data generally.

Trade is the exception. Niger's National Single Window, operational since April 2021, added a licensing and permits module in 2024 that links the Directorates General of Customs, Taxes and the Treasury for cross-agency data exchange. Where registers do connect, they connect on paper: a certified copy of the business register certificate is required before the tax administration will issue a company its fiscal identification number, and both identifiers are then recorded together in the e-invoicing system SECeF. Sectoral stores stay apart — health reporting is fragmented across dozens of platforms, agricultural information systems run separately with no unified farmer database — and a national internet exchange point is one of six critical digital infrastructures the government set out to deploy in July 2025.

Digital Identity and CRVS

Mass enrolment for the CNIB-AES biometric national identity card began on 25 April 2026 at Niamey's Yantala commissariat, rolling out across the capital's twenty commissariats before extending to the interior, after President Tiani enrolled as the first holder on 27 March. The interior ministry put the card and passport contract with the Libyan supplier at 85 per cent executed in March 2026, with production in Niamey only and two million cards a year planned over five years. The card is issued to citizens aged 15 and over, valid for five years, captures fingerprint, facial, voice and iris biometrics, and costs 4,500 CFA francs. About 13 million Nigeriens aged 14 and over are legally required to hold a national identity card, a number officials place far above the number who actually hold one (August 2026).

Two foundational-identity tracks are running at once: a sovereignty-branded AES card and passport built with a Libyan vendor, and a World Bank programme piloting the open-source MOSIP platform with an Indian supplier.

The second is far smaller: the WURI project's MOSIP lab has registered around 500 people (2026). WURI-Niger, launched in October 2022, was restructured after July 2023 and folded into the Refondation programme, making the World Bank project the statutory backbone of the new National Population Register, and it carries an objective of issuing national digital ID to at least 22 million people by 2026. A World Bank progress report recorded the national identity law still awaiting validation in January 2025, and the foundational identity system not yet procured.

Reach is the weak point. A World Bank case study found 55% of the population facing difficulties obtaining identity credentials (2022), against a third-of-54 Ibrahim Index ranking on public perception of how easy an identity document is to obtain, at 79.2 out of 100 in 2023. The WURI system is designed to cover every person physically present on the territory irrespective of nationality or legal status, and UNHCR recorded biometric registration and identity card issuance for Malian and Nigerian refugees in October 2024. Oversight rests with the Ministry of the Interior, which chairs the project's steering and technical committees, and enrolment for the AES biometric passport opened on 16 July 2026, produced by the police with the Libyan supplier Al Itissal Al Jadeed and a local partner. Enrolment for the confederation's biometric national identity card opened in Agadez on 15 September 2026, with biometrics collected at the regional police headquarters and processed centrally; no count of cards enrolled or issued is published.

Digital Payments and Fintech

One structure in Niger held a BCEAO licence to operate as a payment institution as at 28 February 2026, out of thirty-one licensed across the West African Monetary Union.

That single licence is the joint-smallest payment-institution sector in the union alongside Guinea-Bissau, against nine in Côte d'Ivoire and eleven in Senegal, and about three per cent of the union's licensed institutions.

The rails are regional. The BCEAO operates the SICA-UEMOA retail clearing system and the STAR-UEMOA real-time gross settlement system for all eight member states, and there is no Niger-only instant retail payment system (2025), with Niger's National Public Treasury sitting as a direct participant in STAR-UEMOA alongside the banks; Nigerien participants were among the 45 authorised across the union to open instant-payment services to the public at the PI-SPI launch on 30 September 2025. Regulation follows the same pattern: Instruction n°001-01-2024 governs the supply of payment services union-wide, binding banks, payment institutions, microfinance institutions and e-money issuers alike and requiring segregation of client funds and strong customer authentication, while customer identification and due diligence are set by Instruction n°003-03-2025 of 18 March 2025. Niger is on the PAPSS network for inbound payments only, reachable through a licensed extended-network partner rather than as a direct participant (June 2026), so outbound cross-border retail payment runs through union settlement or operators' own products.

Airtel Money Niger SA is the country's first electronic money issuer licensed by the BCEAO, and in August 2026 it opened international transfer — inbound remittances from eight countries through MoneyGram, PayPal Xoom and other partners, and outbound wallet-to-wallet payments to seven UEMOA states over its own network rather than a regional interbank rail. Accounts are many and mostly idle: Niger counted 9,746,822 mobile-money accounts in 2024, 4.53% of them active against 30.90% across the union. Moov Money runs domestic transfers and utility bill payment over USSD. Public payments lag: the tax administration's e-SISIC portal has taken electronic filing and payment since September 2019, Niamey's municipal tax platform collects through mobile money operators, and digital disbursement of government-to-person payments remains at pilot stage (2023). Access to banking services is Niger's third worst Ibrahim Index indicator, at 4.1 out of 100 in 2023 and 48th of 54 African states. The delegated operator of the vehicle one-stop shop opened payment of some of its services through a mobile-money operator on 1 October 2026, by app or offline code, which the transport ministry framed as traceability of public revenue.

Registries

Niger's April–May 2026 identity legislation establishes three registers, the national civil-status register (RNEC) among them. The National Population Register will assign each person a unique number that becomes the access key to any public or private service conditioned on prior identification, and is designed to interoperate with civil-status management, the biometric identity card and travel documents; enrolment starts in Niamey before extending to the rest of the country.

Underneath it, civil registration is still largely manual. The INCI computerisation platform is operational in 103 of Niger's 266 communes, while most rural registry and declaration centres record births by hand and forward them on paper (2025), and a continental assessment of civil-registration digitalisation found electronic civil registration databases operating in urban towns only (2023). The birth-declaration rate stood at 79 per cent in 2026, against 53.48 per cent declared within the legal deadline in 2022, and Civil Registration is the most deteriorated indicator in Niger's Public Administration sub-category on the Ibrahim Index, down 12.5 points over 2014-2023 to 50.0 out of 100. Diffa is the outlier, with 173,109 birth certificates issued between July 2023 and July 2026 lifting timely declaration in the region to 88.04 per cent in 2025.

Other registers are partial too. The business register has been held electronically since 2019 but only for enterprises registered in Niamey, with regional tribunals still registering businesses on paper outside the national database. Formal land registration is minimal: around 4.5% of the population holds legally authenticated documentation for its farmland, and roughly 32,000 titles issued since the cadastre was created in 1906, while cadastre digitisation has scanned maps, registries and titles and installed document management software, leaving geo-referencing and title management unimplemented. The Registre Social Unifié is operational and still expanding, with household validation missions in Maradi and Zinder, but a September 2025 assessment found it not yet deployed nationwide, and the first biometric electoral register, handed over in September 2020, held 7,446,556 voters against an estimated eligible electorate of 9,751,462 and was judged reliable by OIF and ECOWAS auditors that month. Addressing is urban only: Niamey's geoportal references more than 3,500 streets (2026). A World Bank diagnostic found identity and civil registration records fragmented across manual systems, with no central database and no linkages between them (2018).

Sectoral management information systems

SIGRHEP, a single biometric human-resources and payroll system for the state, is being built to replace the ageing systems serving roughly 200,000 public agents, the public-service minister telling the Refondation consultative body in July 2026 that the absence of an integrated system limits control of the wage bill — when it was presented that month, 16,500 personnel files had been digitised and 23,000 updated, in a design that holds biometric identification, payroll and career management together so the same record serves establishment control and salary payment. At least 150 human-resources and payroll managers across the public service are to operate it.

Revenue administration is the oldest and deepest of the sectoral systems: customs has run Sydonia World since April 2016, and the tax administration has run computerised taxpayer registration, unique taxpayer identification and central management of declarations and payments through its AFP and SISIC systems since 1996, and its free online certified e-invoicing platform, e-SECeF, launched in February 2023, had 13,000 users and 145,000 invoices by February 2024. Elsewhere the digital layer sits above paper. The health management information system runs on DHIS2: the ministry's monitoring guide has each health establishment fill a standard monthly activity report and key it into the platform, with health posts sending theirs to a health centre to be keyed (2023), a prescribed circuit and not a measured practice, and a 2025 paper warns of fragmentation and duplicated indicators between digital health platforms and the district reporting system. Education statistics come from an annual school census on printed

questionnaires placed in schools, sent up to the regional level for correction and keyed there and centrally (2025). The Gendarmerie's central case-file and search registry still operates on physical index cards (2023), and a committee to draft a national e-justice strategy was installed in June 2024, with no draft published since.

Public financial management is Niger's strongest administrative measure on the Ibrahim Index and is losing ground: Budgetary & Financial Management scored 73.6 out of 100 in 2023, twelfth of 54 African states and down 7.0 points over the decade, while Tax & Revenue Mobilisation sat at 41.8, thirtieth of 54. The health ministry's monitoring guide set every health establishment to key its own monthly report into DHIS2.

A European trust fund account of May 2019 put over 8,000 cases in the national police database, with about 700 added a month. The programme's newsletter recorded 26 sites in Niamey equipped by August 2019.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Public Administration is one of Niger's three best-scoring Ibrahim Index sub-categories, at 57.5 out of 100 in 2023 and 21st of 54 African states, with its Effective Administration indicator up 7.2 points over the decade to 56.8 — a standing the country's place in the low band of the UN E-Government Development Index (2024) does not match.

Service delivery centres on the service-public.ne citizen portal launched under the Niger 2.0 strategy, with interoperability appearing as a theme within broader digital transformation policy rather than as a plan of its own, which ANSI relaunched on 16 July 2025 as the Portail Public, adding online services in stages without publishing a service list. Procurement runs on SIGMAP, mandatory since 2017 with electronic signature and online approval provided for in 2023, though a procurement official writes that most steps remain offline (February 2026). Inside ministries, ANSI's electronic document and mail platform, hosted on national servers, reached the justice ministry in July 2025 and the foreign ministry and embassies in December 2025. The government is pursuing a "zéro papier" agenda jointly with the digital agency ANSI, the telecoms regulator ARCEP and the data protection authority HAPDP (March 2025). ANSI itself has been given a systems-integration role in the identity stack, alongside the central biometric identity card production service and the territorial surveillance directorate (August 2026), and it built Niamey's municipal tax collection platform, putting the national agency behind a sub-national system. A proposal to turn the national employment agency ANPE into a single-window employment agency alongside SIGRHEP went to the Refondation consultative body in July 2026.

Two limits run through all of it. Niger publishes public records considerably better than it lets citizens reach them, and digitisation stops at the capital's edge — the business register is held electronically only for enterprises registered in Niamey.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Niamey has run its own digital municipal tax platform since Naneye Yarda launched in January 2025, worked by 50 field agents who geolocate taxpayers as they collect, more than two thousand of them located by the launch, giving the city a located record of its municipal tax base. The system was built by ANSI, the national digital agency, which puts the central technology body behind a system owned by one commune, and collection is paired with an automated audit of every transaction and taken through the mobile-money operators Al Izza and Nita.

What the capital has, the rest of the country largely does not. The commercial and moveable-credit register was held electronically only for enterprises registered in Niamey, with regional tribunals still processing business registrations manually and outside the national database (2022). Civil-status computerisation reaches a minority of Niger's 266

communes, with roll-out continuing under a 2023-2027 plan (2025), a picture the WURI project's own account of its digital état civil platform matches (2026). Enrolment in the National Population Register is likewise to begin in Niamey's five arrondissements communaux before extending to the other regions.

Central government has started taking the reforms outward: a national tour explaining civil-registration and identification changes region by region reached Agadez on 28 August 2026 as its fourth stage, briefing administrative and traditional authorities on the population register, the biometric identity card, WURI and the new identification agency.

Rural digital data capture

Niger's rural digital effort rests on a single operation: the World Bank's Smart Villages for Rural Growth and Digital Inclusion loan, USD 100 million committed for rural broadband, digital financial services and digital skills, which was still running and due to end in 2026.

Agriculture is where rural digital services actually operate, and they operate apart from one another: the SIMA and SIMB market information systems and RECA's e-Extension service, which had digitally profiled 24,000 farmers by 2024, run separately, with no unified farmer database and no link to any government data exchange. A national e-Agriculture strategy with a costed 2023-2027 action plan of 22 projects names interoperability between those platforms as an aim (2024).

Elsewhere in government, capture in rural areas is still done by hand. Electronic civil registration databases operate in urban towns only, leaving the rural majority outside digital registration (2023); the annual school census is completed on printed questionnaires placed in schools and keyed at regional and central level (2025); and the national health information system takes monthly activity reports keyed into DHIS2, with health posts sending theirs to a health centre to be keyed (2023). Diffa is the outlier: mobilisers, mobile teams, mobile court hearings and a few computerised communes have lifted timely birth declaration in the region well above the national rate (July 2026).

Power sets the ceiling on all of it, with electricity access sharply urban in 2023. The policy effort scores better than the delivery: Rural Economy is Niger's second best-scoring Ibrahim Index sub-category at 65.4 out of 100 in 2023, 21st of 54 African states, with Rural Economy Support the fourth most improved indicator, up 24.0 points to 72.0, while Rural Market Access has fallen 12.6 points over the decade to 72.4 and Rural Land & Water Access stands at 46.7 (2023).

Technology

AI

Niger had adopted no national artificial intelligence strategy, policy or public AI programme as at September 2026. What runs is a single advisory tool: Rayuwa, a text and voice assistant with image-based crop diagnosis for producers, on which the meteorology, water and plant-protection services were trained in August 2025; its operator's institutional status is not stated and no user count is published.

ICT Industry

Niger's rules for business and competition are among its stronger governance measures, scoring 66.5 out of 100 and ranking 14th of 54 African states (2023), up 5.4 points over the decade — while the wider business and labour environment those rules sit within scores 42.0 and ranks 33rd. The gap is between what the statute book allows and what a firm actually meets.

The mobile market is led by Airtel Niger, which in January 2026 began selling "Starlink by Airtel", a telco-integrated satellite service under the Bharti Airtel–SpaceX partnership with Niger among the first African markets to trial it. Under that model the operator rather than the customer holds the Starlink relationship, a different arrangement from the direct retail sale of kits that has governed Starlink in Niger since 2025 — satellite capacity sold as an operator product, on an operator's billing relationship, rather than as an imported dish.

Domestically built software reaches the market in ones. Direct Go, an e-commerce and delivery platform built by the Nigerien firm Silsila Tech, took first prize in the 2021 e-Takara competition and now runs at version 6.0.0, listing open pharmacies with routing directions alongside its ordering service.

How large any of this is cannot be said from official statistics, because Niger has run no business or establishment survey at all in the decade to 2023, while household, health, agricultural and labour force surveys have gone ahead. A sector no survey instrument reaches is a sector no industrial policy can be aimed at.

Innovation ecosystem

Nigerien companies raised no disclosed venture capital between 2023 and 2025: the country is absent from the Partech Africa venture funding tracker for those years, as it is from the AVCA and Africa: The Big Deal datasets. Niger ranked 132nd in WIPO's Global Innovation Index (2024), near the bottom of the ranked economies.

The institutions are nonetheless in place, and older than the funding gap suggests. CIPMEN, established in 2014, has incubated 222 companies and trained nearly 8,000 people (2025), with Niger Digital, Global IT and Sadit Technologies among its portfolio. AfriLabs counts three Nigerien hubs among its members — CIPMEN, Cabinet Hub Zinder and STRAT-CORE Plus (2022) — alongside independently operating hubs including Sahel Incubateur and MouganiLab. The Cité de l'Innovation de Sadoré opened in 2022 with government, AFD and EU funding, housing a Fab Lab and Codeloccol, Niger's first coding school.

What comes out of that machinery is trading rather than capitalised. Direct Go, the e-commerce and delivery platform that won first prize in the 2021 e-Takara competition, earns from a commission on partner merchants' pre-tax order value and a delivery fee — revenue from customers, not from investors. A sector with an incubator of that age, a publicly funded innovation city and a coding school, and no recorded equity investment behind any of it, is one where the pipeline into a company exists and the pipeline into growth does not.

Capacity

Literacy

Education is Niger's second weakest sub-category in the Ibrahim Index of African Governance, at 37.4 out of 100 in 2023, 44th of 54 African states and 2.4 points lower than a decade earlier, with enrolment at 18.3 and quality at 11.3, both 50th on the continent, and completion the weakest of all 96 scores recorded for the country.

The teaching workforce is the exception rather than the rule. Human Resources in Education scored 90.5 out of 100 in 2023, 17th of 54 African states, against enrolment, completion and quality all sitting in the continent's bottom ten — staffing and teacher qualification are not what is holding the system back, and the ratios themselves are partly a product of how few children are in school to be taught.

What the school system knows about itself is assembled on paper, through an annual census completed by school heads and passed up via the regional education directorates before it is entered centrally, with no digital capture at school level.

Training and skills

The Université Islamique du Niger's Faculté des Sciences et Techniques had produced more than 1,200 ICT and telecommunications graduates since 2009 as at 2022, the country's most substantial single pipeline of formally qualified technical staff.

Beyond the universities, skills provision runs through individual institutions rather than a system. Niger's first coding school, Codeloccol, opened with a Fab Lab at the Cité de l'Innovation de Sadoré in 2022; the incubator CIPMEN has combined incubation with training since 2014; and shorter courses arrive through donors and corporate foundations, such as the digital financial tools programme for women in agri-food processing and pottery in Zinder in August 2026. The state is buying in its own technical staff: in May 2026 the smart-villages project called for a firm to source, train and carry young digital talent under contract for the information-society agency ANSI. Niamey also hosted the 13th AfricaCERT Handshake symposium in July 2025, opened by the Prime Minister.

Research institutions

Niger ranked 132nd in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2024, near the bottom of the ranked economies.

Inclusion

Access to services

Niger's social safety nets scored 22.6 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index for 2023, 38th of 54 African states and 8.4 points down over the decade, inside a social protection and welfare sub-category that fell 5.7 points to 39.9 over the same period.

Identity is the gate in front of most services. A World Bank study of the WURI programme found much of the population has difficulty obtaining identity credentials, and the biometric card whose mass enrolment opened in 2026 carries a charge rather than being issued free. A money-transfer operator placed payment kiosks at enrolment sites in April 2026 so applicants could settle the fee and get a receipt, which eases collection rather than cost. Formal banking access is among the country's three worst indicators on the same index.

Coverage by design is wider than coverage in fact. The WURI foundational system is built to reach every person present on Niger's territory irrespective of nationality, legal status or residency, with biometric registration and identity cards recorded for Malian and Nigerian refugees in 2024, and refugees and asylum-seekers may register births, deaths and marriages on the same conditions as nationals under the 2019 civil status law.

Delivery runs behind that design. The Registre Social Unifié is operational and still expanding through household validation missions in Maradi and Zinder, but was not yet deployed nationwide as at 2025, and digital disbursement of government payments to people remains at pilot stage, with digitised social transfers piloted in the same two regions and a treasury payment system still in preparation.

Redress has an online channel for the administration but not for money: the ombudsman has taken and tracked complaints against public bodies online since September 2021, while a national survey of digital-financial-services risks validated in December 2025 found users unaware of their routes to redress.

Where inclusion work has been concrete it has been small and specific. Five hundred women in agri-food processing and pottery in Zinder completed a ten-day Airtel Africa Foundation course in business management, financial planning and the use of digital financial tools in August 2026. The state's framing has moved the same way: opening

the national civil-status tour at Dosso in August 2026, the region's governor singled out rural populations, vulnerable people, children, women and displaced persons and said identification must be a factor of inclusion and not of exclusion.

Digital divides

The line that decides who is counted in Niger runs between town and country: the electronic civil registration databases operate in urban towns only, so the rural majority is enrolled, where it is enrolled at all, on paper. Electrification has the same shape, rural access running at a fraction of the urban rate in 2023, and the Ibrahim Index puts Niger near the bottom of the continent on access to energy — the divide in digital services sits on top of a divide in the power to run them.

Identification is where that geography is priced. Mass enrolment for the biometric national card is not issued free of charge, and the online route to it reaches few, with internet use still low in 2024. Officials themselves place the number of Nigeriens legally obliged to hold a card far above the number who actually hold one.

On sex the measurement is old: mobile phone ownership among women in Niger was last read against men's in 2015, and sat far below it.

What is being spent against the geography is largely one operation — the World Bank's Smart Villages programme for rural broadband, digital financial services and digital skills, still active in 2026. Commercial satellite service has arrived alongside it, Starlink having been officially on sale since March 2025, and diaspora money is starting to reach household purchases directly through a Niamey delivery startup now accepting Visa and Mastercard from abroad. None of it touches what actually limits the sector, which is that education remains among Niger's weakest showings on the Ibrahim Index.

Data

National statistics

Niger's 2025 business census counted 153,661 formally registered enterprises, a stocktake of the formal economy in a country that had run no business or establishment survey at all in the decade to 2023, against three or more household, health and agricultural rounds and two labour force surveys over the same period. The same indicators place a population census and an agricultural census within the previous twenty years and a business census within ten (2023). The statistics institute's yearbook for 2020-2024, covering demography, health, education and national accounts, was validated on 30 April 2025.

The weakness sits in collection rather than in what is done with the results. On the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators for 2023 Niger scores above 89 per cent on data use but only 20 to 49 per cent on data sources, the weakest of the five pillars, with data products at 70 to 89 per cent and both data services and data infrastructure in the 50 to 69 per cent band. The Ibrahim Index puts the capacity of the statistical system at 43.8 out of 100 in 2023, 33rd of 54 African states and 3.2 points higher than a decade earlier.

Much of what feeds those figures is still gathered on paper. The annual school census is completed by school heads, collected through the regional education directorates and only then keyed centrally into the STATEDUC application, with no digital capture at school level and rural schools without the power or connectivity to attempt it (2025); civil registration is likewise largely paper, its digitisation confined to a partial rollout in which Niamey records reach a central server (2023).

Four different national birth-registration rates were quoted at official events within three weeks of August 2026 — 79 per cent, 80 per cent, 79.63 per cent and, for 2023, 60 per cent — none of them attached to a named survey instrument, which leaves the country's own civil-registration coverage fixed at roughly four-fifths and no finer.

Open data

Niger publishes public records far better than it lets anyone reach them: on the Ibrahim Index, disclosure of public records rose 17.8 points over 2014 to 2023 to reach 38.7 out of 100, 18th of 54 African states and one of the country's ten most improved indicators, while accessibility of public records reached only 26.7, 32nd of 54 and up 4.8 over the same decade.

The statistics institute licenses its published data free and worldwide, commercial reuse included, with attribution, and lists household, food-security and living-conditions survey microdata in a central NADA catalogue (December 2024). What it puts online varies sharply by subject. In the Open Data Watch ODIN 2024 assessment the strongest categories are health facilities at 8.5 out of 10, with balance of payments, government finance and pollution statistics at 8.0 each; the weakest are international trade at 3.0, price statistics and crime and justice at 4.5 each, and built environment, education facilities, education outcomes and health outcomes at 5.0 apiece.

Across the twenty-three categories assessed in 2024 the scores average 5.8 out of 10, with only four at 8 or above and eight at 5 or below.

Two bodies of public rules can be read without asking anyone. The central bank publishes the operating rules of STAR-UEMOA, covering settlement finality, priority processing and settlement-account checks, alongside SICA-UEMOA's operating procedures and participation requirements for the payment systems Niger uses, and the data protection authority sets out on its own site the right of access individuals hold under article 27 of the data protection law, including over data held in identity systems.

Use of satellite data

Niamey's municipal tax platform Naneye Yarda is worked by 50 field agents who geolocate taxpayers as they collect, giving the capital a located record of its municipal tax base built from the ground rather than from imagery (January 2025).

Imagery has steered a public payment once: a satellite water-requirement index triggered drought cash transfers to 15,400 households in November 2021, and a 2024 World Bank test of three satellite drought indexes as transfer triggers found none best everywhere. Niger hosts one of four African regional stations receiving meteorological satellite data directly, built with EUR 20m from the African Development Bank (2021).

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

American capacity is now sold in Niger over a mobile operator's own counter: in January 2026 Airtel Niger commercialised "Starlink by Airtel" under the Bharti Airtel–SpaceX partnership, with Niger among the first African markets to trial the arrangement.

The route to that point was short. Niger's authorities signed a partnership agreement with SpaceX on 29 October 2024, presenting it as part of the national effort to close the digital divide, and kits went on public sale the following March through the company's website and approved resellers.

Washington has not stayed at arm's length from the commercial side of this. The United States Embassy's economic adviser attended the launch of NINETEC's Starlink distribution campaign in Niamey in April 2025 — an American official standing at the rollout of American satellite connectivity in a Sahel state under military government. One company therefore carries the whole visible United States position here, and sells three ways at once: direct to households, through a Nigerien distributor, and bundled by the largest mobile operator in the market.

China activities

Niger's national fibre backbone was built on Chinese credit and is still being paid for. China Eximbank committed a government concessional loan of RMB 623.7 million — about US$103.8 million in constant 2023 dollars — for the National Backbone Fibre Optic Cable Network and Communication Service Project, signed on 2 January 2014, ratified by the National Assembly on 29 October 2014 and handed over to the authorities in the first quarter of 2017.

It bought a great deal of physical plant: more than 2,275 km of fibre on the Niamey–Tillabéry, Zinder–Diffa and Agadez–Tahoua routes, 136 GSM and WCDMA sites, CDMA and ADSL networks and e-government services. The terms were soft — a 20-year maturity, a seven-year grace period, 1% interest and a 0.25% commitment fee, with the state operator SONITEL responsible for repayment — but the length is the point: servicing runs on well past the working life of the equipment the loan financed.

That single 2014 commitment still outweighs anything since. The largest live commitment to Niger's digital sector is the World Bank's USD 100 million Smart Villages for Rural Growth and Digital Inclusion loan (P167543), running to 2026; the Chinese backbone loan, closed in 2017, remains the largest of any kind.

Only four financiers appear in Niger's digital sector at all (September 2026). The World Bank leads with about USD 108 million across two Niger-specific operations, but China Eximbank's one loan, at about USD 104 million, comes within a few million dollars of that whole total, and dwarfs the Netherlands at about USD 8 million and MIGA at USD 2 million.

EU activities

European money in Niger's digital sector is visible in a building rather than a policy: the Cité de l'Innovation de Sadoré opened in 2022 on funding from the Nigerien government, the French development agency AFD and the European Union, housing a Fab Lab and Codeloccol, the country's first coding school.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf or Emirati investment in Niger's digital sector was under way as at September 2026.

India activities

Indian capital entered Niger's connectivity market in January 2026, when Airtel Niger launched "Starlink by Airtel", the telco-integrated satellite service created by the Bharti Airtel–SpaceX partnership, with Niger among the first African markets to trial it. The significance is less the satellite than the channel: an Indian-owned operator, not an American one, is the party selling American capacity to Nigerien subscribers.

Indian suppliers have also reached the identity programme. The Indian vendor BioEnable ran a MOSIP-based biometric enrolment pilot in February 2025 under WURI-Niger and the Interior Ministry, working with dual-iris scanners across the four communes of Tanout, Mayahi, Doutchi and Tagazar — an open-source identity track running alongside, and separate from, the regional AES card.

Digital sovereignty

Niger's identity and travel documents now run on a Libyan vendor's infrastructure under the Alliance of Sahel States' standard: public enrolment for the AES biometric passport opened in Niamey on 15 September 2026, with the Libyan firm Al Itissal Al Jadeed in charge of the identity infrastructure, completing the AES states' replacement of the ECOWAS travel regime. The memoranda of June 2025 give the firm the design, financing, construction and maintenance of the passport system and the new electronic identity card under a public-private partnership. The terms on which the Al Itissal Al Jadeed agreements govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026, and where the biometric identity database is hosted, and under whose jurisdiction, had not been published as at September 2026.

The state's own hosting is close to built. Civil works on the national data centre were finished and its technical equipment was being installed in June 2026, and its feasibility study sized it to host government applications and to sell hosting to businesses from part of its space (June 2026). No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026. The data protection law lets personal data leave only for states offering equivalent protection, with authorisation, a power that passed to the ministries of justice and the interior when the data protection authority was abolished in June 2026.

The continental layer is the AES rather than ECOWAS. The 2025 finance law gave 300 million CFA francs to interconnecting the customs information systems of the AES states, and Niger sent its civil-registration, digital-agency, biometric-card, legal and finance officials to study Burkina Faso's identification system in July 2026.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	**2026-10-18**
COMPILED	By Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/NER/NER-status-2026-10-18.pdf
FEEDBACK	info@data-landscapers.io
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